

VOTING RITE
Women casting their ballot at a polling station in Agra, May 7

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

lot aids this sense of independence and rational choice-making. And if they do vote as a family, Roscher points out, it is because it "makes them a force to reckon with, and serves as a bargaining tool with political parties". Women, particularly the younger cohort, are also becoming more engaged, she adds. They are now voting in their 20s when their mothers would have first voted in their 40s.

Aware of their growing heft, political parties across the spectrum have pivoted their welfare narratives in the service of the country's women. Some state governments led the way. It was Nitish Kumar in Bihar and Shivraj Singh Chouhan in Madhya Pradesh who perhaps first demonstrated the political capital to be made by cultivating women as a vote bank. If Nitish gave female students who finished Class VIII money to buy cycles and also introduced prohibition to win over the woman voter, Chouhan made Ladli Behna the centrepiece of his campaign, successfully delivering his state to the BJP in the assembly polls last year.

In the East, Mamata Banerjee in West Bengal and Naveen Patnaik in Odisha have made a success of their respective flagship schemes—Kanyashree and Mission Shakti. The Trinamool Congress (TMC) and the Biju Janata Dal (BJD) also field a significant number of female candidates out of their total nominees—the TMC has 12 women of 42 and the BJD seven of 21 in this Lok Sabha election. The Congress, too, is beginning to reap the dividends of women-centric poll promises—its Gruha Lakshmi and Mahalaxmi schemes guarantee cash incentives and free travel, which helped the party win Karnataka first and then Telangana last year.

The Modi Effect

But no one has crafted welfare around women better than Narendra Modi and the BJP. Realising early his appeal among the women voters, Modi began wooing the constituency systematically the moment he came to power at the Centre in 2014. Every scheme he launched, he put dedicated it to the cause of women. Thus, Jan Dhan accounts (in which women are said to have a 55.9 per cent share) would help them get direct benefit transfers, MUDRA loans aid their economic empowerment, PM Awas Yojana give them houses in their names. Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao was an exhortation to educate the girl child. *Nari sashaktikaran* (women's empowerment) became a rallying cry, it is how the reservation bill too was named—Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam.

Name any indicator on the multidimensional poverty index (MPI), and Modi devised a scheme for it with an inbuilt focus on women—the JAM (Jan Dhan, Aadhaar, Mobile) trinity for their financial inclusion, Ujjwala for cooking fuel, Swachh Bharat for sanitation, Jal Jeevan Mission for drinking water, Poshan Abhiyan for nutrition, Matru Vandana for maternal health. That showed up in a declining MPI, from 29.17 per cent in 2013-14 to 11.28 per cent in 2022-23, according to a research paper by NITI Aayog. With 300 million-plus women expected to vote this election, Modi is hoping that the *mahila labharthi* will overlook caste and identity considerations and hand him and his party a third consecutive term.

A lot of women," says Sirnate, "voted for Modi in 2014 and 2019, because he came across as a strong, appealing alpha male." Hence the prime minister's enduring brand recall, as research studies bear out Modi's impact on the women voter. During her fieldwork in rural Bihar, for instance, Rithika Kumar found that women who did not know the name of their *mukhiyas* or chief minister (Nitish Kumar!) were readily able to identify Modi. She quotes female respondents as saying "Modi *sarkar hai* (he is the government)" or Modi Bharat *ke malik hain* (he is the leader of the country). Modi remains popular in the female perception, as evident in the February 2024 INDIA TODAY MOTN survey, where he had a 39 percentage point lead over his nearest rival Rahul Gandhi on who should be the next PM (see *Mood of the Nation's Women*). The NDA government's performance received a thumbs up too, with its handling of the pandemic regarded as its single-biggest achievement among the female respondents, with 21.3 per cent of them selecting this option rather than the government's welfare schemes or the construction of the Ram temple in Ayodhya.

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What may also work in the BJP's favour is the effective communication of its strategy. While Modi provides the lead and the narrative, the BJP cadre does the rest, bringing its booth management skills to bear on the female constituency. Giving a glimpse of that strategy, Vanathi Srinivasan, national president of the BJP Mahila Morcha, says at the booth level, ASHA and anganwadi workers are identified and targeted. At the district level, influential women involved in NGOs